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Update

Bangladeshis make up 12% of Mediterranean migrant deaths, says IOM chief

The Central Mediterranean route, witnessing 20,000 deaths or disappearances between 2014 and 2022, is the deadliest migration path globally

File image: A group of 61 migrants on a wooden boat are rescued by crew members of the Geo Barents migrant rescue ship, operated by Medecins Sans Frontieres (Doctors Without Borders), in international waters off the coast of Libya in the central Mediterranean Sea on September 28, 2023 Photo: Reuters

Tribune Desk

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Bangladeshis comprised 12% of the migrants who tragically lost their lives attempting to cross the Mediterranean to reach Europe this year, according to Amy Pope, the director general of the UN's International Organization for Migration (IOM).

Pope disclosed this statistic during the launch of the IOM's World Migration Report 2024 at a Banani hotel in the capital on Tuesday.

Media reports quoted Pope as saying: "12% of the deaths of those crossing the Mediterranean this year have been nationals of this country."

However, she could not provide an exact count immediately.

Earlier this month, the families of eight Bangladeshis received the bodies of their loved ones who had perished in a boat capsize off the Tunisian coast while en route to Europe across the Mediterranean Sea.

The boat, carrying 52 passengers and a sailor from the coast of Zuwarah on its way to Europe, sank on February 14.

Among the survivors, 27 were Bangladeshi nationals, while the others hailed from Pakistan (8), Syria (5) and Egypt (4).

Nine lives were lost, with eight identified as Bangladeshis and one as Pakistani.

Deadliest route

According to the IOM report, North Africa serves as a departure point for thousands of migrants embarking on perilous journeys, primarily along the Western and Central Mediterranean routes. In countries like Libya, which act as transit points, extensive smuggling and trafficking networks have thrived over time.

Reports have documented instances of beatings, torture and forced labour inflicted on migrants in Libya, particularly at maritime departure points toward Europe.

Thousands of migrants have also lost their lives.

The central Mediterranean route stands as the world's deadliest migration path, witnessing over 20,000 deaths or disappearances between 2014 and 2022, says the latest IOM migration report.

From 2014 through the end of 2023, the IOM's Missing Migrants Project documented over 63,000 deaths and disappearances along migration routes.

Year-to-year, 2023 saw an increase in deaths across the Mediterranean, Africa and Asia

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